EVOFIT

RPE Cheat Sheet

Rate of Perceived Exertion — The trainer's intensity guide

FREE RESOURCE
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RPE measures how hard an exercise feels on a scale of 1–10. Use it to prescribe intensity without a 1RM test. Pair with Reps In Reserve (RIR) for precision programming.

RIR = Reps left in the tank

ZONES: 1–4 Recovery / Easy · 5–6 Light / Moderate · 7–8 Hard / Heavy · 9–10 Very Hard / Max

RPE	ZONE	HOW IT FEELS	EXAMPLE / PROGRAMMING USE	RIR
1	**Rest** *No effort at all*	Complete rest. No physical exertion. Lying still or seated comfortably. Breathing is totally normal.	**USE FOR:** Rest intervals between max-effort sets. Not typically prescribed in programs.	∞ unlimited reps left
2	**Very Light** *Barely moving*	Minimal effort. Slow walking pace. Could sustain this for hours. No real challenge to breathing or muscles.	**EXAMPLE:** Easy walk, mobility drills, warm-up foam rolling, gentle stretching.	∞ unlimited reps left
3	**Light** *Easy, comfortable*	Slight exertion. Can hold a full conversation. Breathing slightly elevated. Used for warm-up sets.	**EXAMPLE:** Warm-up sets at 40–50% 1RM. Light band work. Technique practice with empty bar.	8+ many reps left
4	**Somewhat Easy** *Noticeable but easy*	Starting to feel the work. Breathing picks up slightly. Still very comfortable — form is perfect, no real challenge.	**EXAMPLE:** Feeder sets at 55–65% 1RM. Deload week loads. Corrective work.	6–7 many reps left
5	**Moderate** *Comfortable effort*	Effort is clear. Can still talk in sentences. Breathing is elevated but not laboured. Could maintain this for many more reps.	**EXAMPLE:** Hypertrophy warm-up sets. Conditioning circuits. 65–70% 1RM loads.	5–6 several reps left
6	**Somewhat Hard** *Challenging, manageable*	Noticeably challenging. Short sentences only. Muscles working steadily. Form is still crisp. Endurance athletes often train here.	**EXAMPLE:** Hypertrophy working sets (early). Accessory lifts. 70–75% 1RM.	4–5 a few reps left
7	**Hard** *Uncomfortable, doable*	Genuinely hard. Single words only. Muscles burning noticeably. Starting to think about stopping — but you wouldn't. Standard hypertrophy zone.	**EXAMPLE:** Main hypertrophy sets. 3–4 reps before failure. ~75–80% 1RM.	3–4 3–4 reps left
8	**Very Hard** *Heavy, demanding*	Very hard. Can barely speak. Muscles significantly fatigued. Would struggle to add another rep without grinding hard. Strength training zone.	**EXAMPLE:** Strength top sets. 2 reps before failure. ~80–87.5% 1RM.	2–3 2–3 reps left
9	**Near Max** *Almost everything*	Near maximal. Talking is impossible. Grinding hard. One rep left — maybe. Bar speed is slow. Requires full mental focus and bracing.	**EXAMPLE:** Peaking sets. 1 rep before failure. ~87.5–95% 1RM. Competition prep.	1 1 rep left
10	**Max Effort** *Absolute limit*	100% effort. True maximum. Could not have done another rep under any circumstances. Bar speed is extremely slow or grinding.	**EXAMPLE:** 1RM attempts. Competition max-outs. True technical failure sets.	0 nothing left

Pro Tip: New clients consistently over-estimate their RPE by 1–2 points. Calibrate in the first 2–3 sessions by asking "how many more reps could you have done?" If they say 5+ but rated it RPE 8, recalibrate. **RPE is a skill — teach it early.**

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EvoFit Trainer logs RPE automatically on every set and tracks training load over time.

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